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GURUSPEAK



"At NIFT Hyderabad, design, culture and craft shape everyday learning, immersing students in Hyderabad's artistic heritage while preparing them to inherit, reinterpret and shape fashion's creative future confidently and purposefully"

PROF. MALINI DIVAKALA
Director, NIFT Hyderabad

technology. Since the 2022 rankings, it has climbed three spots to No. 4, making it the most improved college in its category. The institute's flagship four-year Bachelor of Design offers highly sought-after options such as fashion design, fashion communication, textile design, knitwear design and fashion/ lifestyle accessory design, which, officials say, cater heavily to the growing retail industry in southern India. The institute also offers a four-year Bachelor of Fashion Technology degree and a two-year Master's in Fashion Management, as well as courses for those who wish to start boutiques or apparel businesses.

NIFT Hyderabad's initiatives link students with Telangana's rich heritage craft hubs, such as Pochampally for ikats, Gadwal for sarees, Pembarthi for metal crafts and Cheriyal for scroll paintings.

The campus, known for its architectural grandeur, stepped terraces and versatile spatial design, is now in what teachers call a modernisation era. It has been incorporating advanced software suites, smart labs and curriculum pathways that integrate 3D virtual clothing simulation, AI tools and UI/UX design into its flagship streams.

The present average annual package at which NIFT Hyderabad students are placed in reputed companies such as Aditya Birla and Hidesign is about Rs 8 lakh per annum.

"NIFT Hyderabad, for me, is much more than a fashion design school," says Nandini Tripathi from New Delhi, a third-year BDes (Fashion Design) student. "It has taught me how to question my assumptions, challenge myself every day, improve and keep making things better. Good design, we are taught, is not meant to impress people but should reflect the needs of the section we are catering to."

For some alumni, NIFT Hyderabad still feels like a home away from home. "It's where I still belong," chuckles Mrunalini Rao, founder and creative head of the eponymous Hyderabad-based label. Rao says she fought her family and gave up medical admission to pursue her passion and join NIFT. She has since designed costumes for several celebrities and sport stars, including Samantha, Rashmika Mandanna, Kiara Advani, Vidya Balan, P.V. Sindhu, Smriti Mandhana, Tilak Varma and Ishan Kishan.

"I thoroughly enjoyed those four years of design school. I am still associated with the college today, giving guest lectures," says Rao, now harbouring a desire to go back to the campus one day for a PhD. ■

TOP 5 MOST IMPROVED COLLEGES FASHION DESIGN

RANK	COLLEGE	CITY	RANK 2026	RANK 2022
1	NATIONAL INSTITUTE OF FASHION TECHNOLOGY (NIFT), HYDERABAD	Hyderabad	4	7
2	IMS DESIGN & INNOVATION ACADEMY	Noida	21	28
3	PEARL ACADEMY, MUMBAI	Mumbai	19	24
4	NATIONAL INSTITUTE OF FASHION TECHNOLOGY (NIFT), KANNUR	Kannur	11	13
5	NATIONAL INSTITUTE OF FASHION TECHNOLOGY (NIFT), BHUBANESWAR	Bhubaneswar	13	15

*The college that has shown the highest improvement in rankings between 2022 and 2026